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An Apology?

One question that is on the lips of everyone who knows of Bhagat Singh's case is whether there should now be a restitution for acts done long ago in the heyday of the British Empire. Should there be an act of atonement for what happened a hundred years ago? All the evidence suggests that by the time of the Lahore Conspiracy Case in 1929, the colonial administration in Punjab knew full well that its sustained and systemic campaign of unabated physical violence on the youth of the land was not working. It was not able to break their resolve or force them to mend their errant ways. It could have granted the Lahore conspirators an amnesty and focussed its resources instead on preventing violent acts from taking place in the first place. Instead, it chose to use the law as a specific tool of colonial coercion by subjecting them to legal repression of the most severe sort through judicial reprisals. Should there not be an atonement for that, one may well ask? In fact, there is the revealing historical fact of how '[i]n November 1929, shortly after Jatin Das' death [following his hunger strike], and as the proceedings for the Lahore Conspiracy trials began, *the highest officials in the colonial government began to consider how to deal with the problem of political prisoners* as they tried to construct a way to evaluate the success of the constitutional reforms of 1919 under Montagu and Chelmsford' (emphases added). Moreover, there was, as Durba Ghosh has pointed out, 'a private letter in November 21, 1929, from Lord Irwin, the viceroy, to Wedgewood Benn, secretary of state for India and Liberal MP', in which

> 'Irwin identified two important issues in terms of dealing with political prisoners and the activities of the revolutionary terrorist movement. One issue was amnesty for political